Week 8: Report Structure, Style and Group Communication

NPTEL Soft Skills · Prof. Binod Mishra · Lectures 36–40

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Lecture 36: Structure of Reports: Part-I

Week 8 · Course book PDF pages 576–592 (printed pages 575–591)

Learning objectives

- State the three structural divisions of a technical report.
- List the items of the prefatory material (front matter) in order.
- Describe the cover page, title page, frontispiece, copyright notice and forwarding letter.
- Differentiate preface and foreword; write an acknowledgement.
- Prepare a table of contents and list of illustrations; differentiate abstract, summary and executive summary.

Important definitions

PREFATORY MATERIAL (FRONT MATTER)

Items preceding the main text of a report: cover, frontispiece, title page, copyright notice, forwarding letter, preface, acknowledgement, table of contents, list of illustrations, abstract.

COVER PAGE

Outer page on thick paper bearing ‘Report on’, title, report number, writer, ‘prepared for’, organisation and month/year.

TITLE PAGE

Page after the cover with the title (and subtitle), prepared for/by, ‘approved by’ and organisation and date.

FRONTISPIECE

A thin protective page, or illustration, facing the title page, giving a window display of the report to create curiosity; used in bound reports.

COPYRIGHT NOTICE

A statement on the back of the title page such as '© Amit Jain 2017. All rights reserved. No part of this report may be reproduced…without written permission'.

FORWARDING LETTER / LETTER OF TRANSMITTAL

A letter by the controlling officer forwarding the report through proper channel; includes authorisation, subject, purpose, scope, limitations and acknowledgement.

PREFACE

The writer's own first page introducing the subject, work done, significance and organisation; kept short.

FOREWORD

A recommendation written by an expert or celebrity, not the author.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

A separate page thanking those who helped, in simple polite language, in 2–3 paragraphs.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Division of the report into parts with page numbers.

LIST OF ILLUSTRATIONS

Separate list of tables, charts, graphs with numbers and pages.

ABSTRACT

A very short condensed statement of the focus of the report, with key words.

SUMMARY

A longer account (up to 1.5–2 pages) of the entire report.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The whole report in a nutshell for top managers: purpose, objectives, methodology, findings, recommendations.

Core concepts

Three parts of a technical report

Prefatory material (front matter) → Main body (text) → Back matter. Like a letter's introduction, middle and end. Check the TOR for what the report needs; short reports need not follow the full structure. Analogy: a palatial building built brick by brick on a foundation.

Items of front matter (order)

1. Cover
2. Frontispiece
3. Title page
4. Copyright notice
5. Forwarding letter
6. Preface
7. Acknowledgement
8. Table of contents
9. List of illustrations
0. Abstract (or summary)

Cover page

- Thick paper, usually white (coloured allowed); many organisations have a proforma.
- Contents: 'Report on', **title** (key words; capitals or initial capitals except prepositions), **report number** (right), **writer's name** (employee or enrollment number), **'Prepared for'** (person), **organisation**, **month and year**.
- Number and date help later researchers.

Title page

- Gives title and **subtitle** (e.g. 'Quality Health Management in Hospitals: A Case Study').
- Prepared for / prepared by; **'Approved by' at lower left** with the controlling officer's name.
- Studies: descriptive (demand of two-wheelers), correlational, causal (effect of pollution on mankind) help in choosing titles.

Frontispiece, copyright, forwarding letter

- **Frontispiece:** only bound, thick reports; protects drawings and charts; now often dropped.
- **Copyright notice:** on the back of the title page with year and 'All rights reserved'.
- **Forwarding letter:** in business-letter format; certifies the report, states authorisation and scope; not mandatory.

Preface versus foreword; acknowledgement

- Preface: by the author; foreword: by an expert as recommendation.
- Keep preface short; put thanks on a separate page.
- Acknowledgement: 2–3 paragraphs, categorise helpers, vary phrases ("I am thankful to…", "I shall be failing in my duty if…"), avoid jargon and metaphor.

Table of contents and illustrations

- Differs from outline by **page numbers**; title in the centre/top.
- Order: Preface, Acknowledgement, Abstract (in *italics*, Roman numerals), then chapters from Introduction with Arabic numbering, then appendix and bibliography.
- Sub-divisions are not essential.
- List of illustrations gives number, title and page of tables and charts (graphs, pie charts) for readers who scan visuals.

Abstract, summary, executive summary

- **Abstract:** very short, key words, main focus; as at conferences.
- **Summary:** longer, covers the report; up to 1.5–2 pages.
- **Executive summary:** whole report in a nutshell: reason for writing, objectives, findings, methodology, recommendations; topic sentences in paragraphs.
- Language: neutral, scientific, detached, no flowery words or jargon; it prepares the reader for the report.

Types, classifications and characteristics

Structure of a technical report

Part	Alternative name	Contents
1	Prefatory material / front matter	Cover to abstract
2	Main body / text	Introduction to recommendation
3	Back matter	Appendix, bibliography, glossary, index

Front matter items

Item	Key point
Cover	Report on, title, number, writer, date
Frontispiece	Thin protective page; optional
Title page	Subtitle, approved by
Copyright	All rights reserved
Forwarding letter	Through channel; not mandatory
Preface	Author’s note; short
Acknowledgement	Thanks; simple language
Table of contents	Page numbers
List of illustrations	Tables and charts
Abstract	Brief, key words

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

Cover: ‘Quality Management in Service Industries’ with report number and month/year.

EXAMPLE

Title page with subtitle ‘A Case Study’.

EXAMPLE

Copyright: Amit Jain © 2017 – All rights reserved.

EXAMPLE

Forwarding letter to Nilesh Mathur.

Comparison tables

Preface versus foreword

Point	Preface	Foreword
Written by	Author	Expert or celebrity
Content	Subject, work done, significance	Recommendation to readers

Abstract versus summary versus executive summary

Point	Abstract	Summary	Executive summary
Length	Very short	1.5–2 pages	Concise but complete
Purpose	Main focus, key words	Entire report	Report in a nutshell for managers
Contains	Focus	Overview	Objectives, methodology, findings, recommendations

Outline versus table of contents

Point	Outline	Table of contents
Page numbers	No	Yes
Stage	Planning	Finished report

Cover page versus title page

Point	Cover	Title page
Material	Thick paper	Ordinary page after cover
Extra items	Report number	Subtitle and ‘approved by’

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- Report has three parts: front matter, main body, back matter.
- Front matter items in order: cover, frontispiece, title page, copyright, forwarding letter, preface, acknowledgement, contents, illustrations, abstract.
- 'Approved by' goes at lower left of the title page.
- Copyright notice on the back of the title page.
- Forwarding letter is also called letter of transmittal.
- Preface by author; foreword by expert.
- Table of contents has page numbers; outline does not.
- Preface, acknowledgement and abstract use Roman numerals/italics.
- Abstract is shorter than summary.
- Executive summary may go up to 1.5–2 pages.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W8 Q2	p.28	Introduction of a report	True/False
W8 Q6	p.28	Executive summary	MCQ
W8 Q13	p.30	Introduction of a report	MSQ

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

A technical report has front matter, main body and back matter. The front matter contains the cover, frontispiece, title page, copyright notice, forwarding letter, preface, acknowledgement, table of contents, list of illustrations and abstract or summary. The cover carries the report number, title, writer, recipient, organisation and date; the title page adds the subtitle and 'approved by'. The preface is by the author, the foreword by an expert. The table of contents carries page numbers. Abstracts and summaries use neutral, concise language.

Practice questions

Q1 (MCQ) The three parts of a technical report are:

A. Front matter, body, back matter

B. Title, text, index

C. Cover, letter, bibliography

D. Preface, summary, appendix

> **Answer:** A
> **Why:** Prefatory material, main elements and back matter.

Q2 (MCQ) A foreword is written by:

A. The author

B. An expert

C. The printer

D. The publisher

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** It recommends the work.

Q3 (MCQ) The 'approved by' line appears on the:

A. Cover top

B. Title page, lower left

C. Index

D. Appendix

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** Controlling officer's approval.

Q4 (MSQ) Which belong to the front matter?

A. Abstract

B. Acknowledgement

C. Bibliography

D. Copyright notice

> **Answer:** A, B, D
> **Why:** Bibliography is back matter.

Q5 (T/F) A table of contents contains page numbers while an outline does not.

> **Answer:** True
> **Why:** That is the difference.

Q6 (Fill) Another name for a forwarding letter is a letter of _____.

> **Answer:** transmittal
> **Why:** It sends the report through channel.

Q7 (Short) Differentiate abstract and executive summary.

> **Answer:** An abstract is a very brief statement of the report's focus with key words; an executive summary is a fuller digest including objectives, methodology, findings and recommendations.
> **Why:** Executive summary suits busy managers.

Revision checklist

☐ I can name the three parts.

☐ I can list front matter in order.
☐ I know cover and title page contents.
☐ I can differentiate preface and foreword.
☐ I know abstract vs summary.

Lecture 37: Structure of Reports: Part-II

Week 8 · Course book PDF pages 593–608 (printed pages 592–607)

Learning objectives

- List the four parts of the main body: introduction, discussion, conclusion, recommendation.
- Describe the contents of an introduction.
- Explain how to write discussion, conclusions and recommendations.
- List the items of back matter: appendix, list of references, bibliography, glossary, index.
- Differentiate bibliography and list of references; APA and MLA styles.

Important definitions

INTRODUCTION

First part of the main body: background, problem, authorisation, scope, limitations, sources and methods, definitions of terms and report preview.

DISCUSSION

The part where data are analysed, interpreted and evaluated to lead logically to the conclusion.

CONCLUSION

Logical inferences and judgments based only on the analysis, with no new information.

RECOMMENDATION

Feasible action suggested on the basis of the conclusions, written only when asked.

BACK MATTER

Supporting material after the main text: appendices, references, bibliography, glossary, index.

APPENDIX

Supporting material (questionnaire, interview sheets, charts) placed at the end; labelled Appendix A, B, C.

LIST OF REFERENCES

Only the works cited in the text; mandatory.

BIBLIOGRAPHY

Complete alphabetical list of works consulted, including those not quoted, for further reading.

GLOSSARY

Alphabetical list of technical terms with meanings.

INDEX

Alphabetical list of topics and sub-topics with page numbers, for very long reports.

APA STYLE

Citation style common in sciences; year follows the author's name.

MLA STYLE

Citation style common in humanities/social sciences; year given near the end.

Core concepts

Four parts of the main body

1. Introduction
2. Discussion
3. Conclusion
4. Recommendation (if asked)

Use decimal numbering; Introduction is 1, Discussion 2 and so on.

Contents of the introduction

- **Historical background** and statement of the problem (about the organisation, sector, or issue).
- **Authorisation** and terms of reference; hypothesis or concept of the problem.
- **Scope** – who or what is affected.
- **Limitations** of the findings and methods.
- **Sources and methods** of data collection.
- **Definitions of terms** for non-expert readers (e.g. the boss).
- **Report preview** – division of the report into sections.

Discussion

- 'The entire drama takes place': analysis, interpretation and evaluation of data.
- Divide into sections and sub-sections with decimal numbers.
- Present findings in tables, graphs and charts that are in sync with the text; useful for busy readers.
- Example: absenteeism – the data may show personal problems, unsuitable unit or poor communication with bosses, not mere insincerity.
- Raise questions and answer them with data.

Conclusion

- Based entirely on the analysis; **no new information**.
- Brief (1–2 pages even for a 30-page report); may be numbered.

- Busy readers read only conclusions and illustrations.

Recommendation

- Give **only when asked**.
- Must be **feasible**, not aggressive or 'the only solution', no personality; maintain equilibrium between truth and feasibility.
- Infeasible or invented recommendations make the report fail.

Back matter items

- **Appendices** (A, B, C) – questionnaires, interview sheets, charts that would block the flow; only interested readers consult them.
- **List of references** – works cited; **bibliography** – all works consulted; **glossary**; **index**.
- Few references can be footnotes on the same page; many go to the end.

Documentation styles

- Order of entry: author (surname first in bibliography; full name in footnote), year (APA: after author), title (italic), edition, place, publisher, year (MLA: at end), pages.
- Types: one, two, three authors, corporate author, e-mail, newspaper article, essay in an edited book, abstract.
- Example MLA: Gibaldi, Joseph. *MLA Handbook for Writers of Research Papers*. New York: Prentice Hall, year.
- Entries are alphabetical; follow your organisation's style (italics or underline).

Glossary and index

- **Glossary:** alphabetical technical terms; essential when many terms (more than 10–20).
- **Index:** alphabetical; main topics and sub-topics; only for extremely long reports.

Types, classifications and characteristics

Main body of a report

Part	Function
Introduction	Background, problem, scope, limitations, methods, definitions, preview
Discussion	Analysis and interpretation of data
Conclusion	Inferences based on analysis
Recommendation	Feasible action; only if asked

Back matter

Item	Content
Appendix	Supporting material
List of references	Works cited
Bibliography	Works consulted
Glossary	Technical terms
Index	Topics with pages

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

Absenteeism report: causes found through data.

EXAMPLE

Unemployment report in a technology or automobile sector.

EXAMPLE

MLA entry for Joseph Gibaldi.

EXAMPLE

Appendices A, B and C for questionnaires.

Comparison tables

Bibliography versus list of references

Point	List of references	Bibliography
Scope	Only cited works	All consulted works
Mandatory?	Yes, if cited	Complete list for further reading
Order	As per style	Alphabetical

APA versus MLA

Point	APA	MLA
Year position	After author’s name	Towards the end
Used in	Sciences	Humanities / social sciences

Glossary versus index

Point	Glossary	Index
Content	Technical terms with meanings	Topics with page numbers
Use	Many technical terms	Very long reports

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- Main body: introduction, discussion, conclusion, recommendation.
- Introduction gives background, authorisation, scope, limitations, methods, definitions and preview.
- Conclusion contains no new information.
- Recommend only when asked and keep it feasible.
- Appendices hold supporting material labelled A, B, C.
- List of references = cited works; bibliography = consulted works.
- APA: year after author; MLA: year at end.
- Bibliography is alphabetical, surname first.
- Glossary and index are alphabetical.
- Index only for extremely long reports.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W8 Q8	p.29	Bibliography vs references	MCQ

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

The main body has introduction (background, authorisation, scope, limitations, methods, definitions, preview), discussion (analysis and interpretation), conclusion (based on analysis, no new data) and recommendation (only if asked and feasible). The back matter holds appendices, list of references, bibliography, glossary and index. A list of references contains only cited works; a bibliography lists all consulted works. APA and MLA differ in the position of the year.

Practice questions

Q1 (MCQ) No new information should appear in the:

A. Introduction

B. Discussion

C. Conclusion

D. Appendix

> **Answer:** C
> **Why:** Conclusions rest on analysis.

Q2 (MCQ) Which gives the full list of consulted works?

A. Glossary

B. Index

C. Bibliography

D. Appendix

> **Answer:** C
> **Why:** References contain only cited works.

Q3 (MSQ) The introduction may contain:

A. Scope

B. Limitations

C. Definitions of terms

D. Final recommendation

> **Answer:** A, B, C
> **Why:** Recommendation is a separate part.

Q4 (T/F) Recommendations should always be added to a report.

> **Answer:** False
> **Why:** Only if asked.

Q5 (Fill) In APA style the _____ follows the author's name.

> **Answer:** year
> **Why:** In MLA it comes near the end.

Q6 (Short) What is placed in appendices?

> **Answer:** Supporting material such as questionnaires, interview sheets and charts that would interrupt the flow of the text.
> **Why:** Labelled Appendix A, B, C.

Revision checklist

☐ I know the four parts of the main body.
☐ I can list introduction contents.
☐ I know conclusion and recommendation rules.
☐ I can list back matter items.
☐ I can differentiate bibliography and references.

Lecture 38: Report Style: Part I

Week 8 · Course book PDF pages 609–630 (printed pages 608–629)

Learning objectives

- Explain why report language must be familiar, specific and simple.
- Identify and correct clichés, jargon, foreign words, redundancy, circumlocution and unfamiliar abbreviations.
- Replace difficult words and phrasal verbs with simple ones.
- Correct misplaced modifiers and use specific rather than vague words.
- Recall Nathaniel Hawthorne's remark on words.

Important definitions

CLICHÉ

A word or phrase once fresh but now overused and stale (e.g. 'threadbare', 'uphill task', 'writing on the wall', 'leave no stone unturned').

JARGON

Technical language of a profession that non-specialist readers cannot follow.

REDUNDANCY

Using unnecessary words that repeat meaning (basic fundamentals, repeat again, final result, great majority).

CIRCUMLOCUTION

A roundabout, wordy way of saying something simple.

FOREIGN WORDS AND PHRASES

Words from other languages (e.g. subpoena, avant-garde, tête-à-tête) that readers may not know.

MODIFIER

A word (adjective/adverb) that describes another; piled-up or misplaced modifiers confuse.

PHRASAL VERB / IDIOM

Verb plus particle (make out, make up) with changed meaning; avoid in reports.

SYNONYM

A word with a near meaning, used to replace a difficult word.

ABBREVIATION

Shortened form; use only if familiar to readers (HIV is fine; FIG, ATR, CVR may not be).

Core concepts

Why style matters

- A report is written to bring action; action requires understanding.
- Readers have different backgrounds (an engineer and a doctor use different terminologies).
- Technical language is needed for technical subjects, but use words that are at least familiar.
- Report language is not only sentences but also words and paragraphs: choose words, phrases, sentences and paragraphs carefully.
- **Hawthorne:** "Words so innocent and powerless as they are, as standing in a dictionary, how potent for good and evil they become in the hands of one who knows how to combine them."

Be specific and familiar

- Avoid unusual words used for an 'air of intellectuality'.
- Be specific: 'the majority were divided' → '70 per cent were divided'.
- Revise and replace difficult words with simple synonyms.

Difficult word replacements

- ramifications → results; corroborate → verify / prove
- veracity → truth; validation → proof
- apogee → orbit (as given); camaraderie → friendship; dismember → cut; impasse → deadlock/difficulty
- obtuse → dull; synergy → unity/coordination
- antiquated → old; annihilation → destruction; conflagration → fire
- cognizant → aware/know; pedagogue → teacher

Examples: "The ramifications of the experiment should be corroborated" → "The result of the lab experiment should be verified." "The veracity of the scientist's claim requires validation" → "The truth of the claim requires proof."

Modifiers and phrasal verbs

- Avoid double modifiers: "all praises and credits", "new and novel structure" – use one word.
- Avoid phrasal verbs: "could not make out" → "could not understand".
- Misplaced modifier: "Speaking before the large audience, my knees began to knock" → "Speaking before the large audience, I felt my knees knocking."

Clichés

- "The report discusses threadbare the problem…" → "…in detail".
- "uphill task" → "challenge"; "writing on the wall" → "prediction".

- “leave no stone unturned” → “work hard / try my best”; “burning question” → “common issue”; “day in and day out”; “repeat again”.

Foreign words, jargon, redundancy, circumlocution

- **Foreign:** subpoena (court summons), avant-garde → pioneer, tête-à-tête → personal interview.
- **Jargon:** “the spectrum of infection with the human immunodeficiency virus continues to evolve...” → “we are learning more about the range of infection in people with HIV”; “pedagogical pursuits” → “teaching”.
- **Redundancy:** basic fundamentals, repeat again, final result, a great majority.
- **Circumlocution:** “We are cognizant that you are experiencing difficulties during this period of reorganisation” → “We know...”.

Abbreviations and slang

- Use only abbreviations the reader knows; explain unfamiliar ones (FIG = Faculty Initiation Grant; CVR = cockpit voice recorder; ATR).
- Avoid campus slang such as ‘insti’, ‘poly class’, ‘audie’ (auditorium), ‘enthu’.
- Take the medium path: maximum familiar words.

Wrong word choice

Confusing *sensitive* with *sensible* leads to awkward writing; the doctor cannot cure what he cannot diagnose, and a solution needs understanding. Next lecture: sentence structure, readability, active/passive.

Types, classifications and characteristics

Faults of word choice in reports

Fault	Meaning	Example → fix
Cliché	Overused expression	threadbare → in detail
Jargon	Technical terminology	pedagogue → teacher
Foreign word	Non-English word	avant-garde → pioneer
Redundancy	Repeated meaning	basic fundamentals → fundamentals
Circumlocution	Roundabout expression	cognizant → know
Unfamiliar abbreviation	Unknown short form	spell out FIG
Phrasal verb	Multi-word idiom	make out → understand

Theories, principles, models and contributors

POWER OF WORDS — NATHANIEL HAWTHORNE

Words are innocent and powerless in a dictionary but become potent for good and evil in the hands of one who combines them.

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

70 per cent instead of ‘majority’.

EXAMPLE

Corroborate → verify.

EXAMPLE

Writing on the wall → prediction.

EXAMPLE

HIV instead of human immunodeficiency virus.

EXAMPLE

‘Audie’ mistaken for an Audi car.

Comparison tables

Difficult versus simple words

Difficult	Simple
ramification	result
corroborate	prove / verify
antiquated	old
annihilation	destruction
conflagration	fire
veracity	truth
camaraderie	friendship
obtuse	dull

Redundant versus correct

Redundant	Correct
basic fundamentals	fundamentals
repeat again	repeat
final result	result
a great majority of people	most people

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- Report language must be simple, specific and familiar.
- Cliché = overused expression.
- Jargon = technical language unknown to the reader.
- Redundancy = unnecessary repetition.
- Circumlocution = roundabout expression.
- Use one modifier, not two.
- Avoid phrasal verbs and idioms.
- Avoid unfamiliar abbreviations and slang.
- Hawthorne's quotation on words.
- Be specific with numbers instead of 'majority'.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W7 Q9	p.26	Circumlocution	MCQ
W7 Q13	p.27	Clarity in report language	MSQ
W8 Q5	p.28	Report style: plain words	True/False
W8 Q9	p.29	Redundancy	MCQ

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

Report language should be simple, specific and familiar so that readers of different backgrounds can act on it. Avoid unusual words, clichés, jargon, foreign phrases, redundancy, circumlocution, phrasal verbs, double modifiers, misplaced modifiers and unfamiliar abbreviations. Replace difficult terms with synonyms, give exact figures and revise. As Hawthorne notes, words become powerful in the hands of one who knows how to combine them.

Practice questions

Q1 MCQ ‘Basic fundamentals’ is an example of:

A. Cliché

B. Redundancy

C. Jargon

D. Foreign phrase

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** Basic and fundamental repeat the meaning.

Q2 MCQ A simpler word for ‘corroborate’ is:

A. Verify

B. Complicate

C. Dispute

D. Delay

> **Answer:** A
> **Why:** Verify or prove.

Q3 MSQ Which are clichés?

A. Uphill task

B. Writing on the wall

C. Leave no stone unturned

D. Result

> **Answer:** A, B, C
> **Why:** ‘Result’ is plain.

Q4 T/F Abbreviations may be used freely without explanation.

> **Answer:** False
> **Why:** Only if familiar to readers.

Q5 Fill A roundabout way of saying a simple thing is _____.

> **Answer:** circumlocution
> **Why:** E.g. ‘We are cognizant…’.

Q6 Short Why should report writers avoid jargon?

> **Answer:** Readers of different backgrounds may not understand technical terms, so the report fails to lead to action.
> **Why:** Use technical but familiar terms like HIV.

Revision checklist

☐ I can define cliché, jargon, redundancy, circumlocution.
☐ I can simplify difficult words.
☐ I can correct misplaced modifiers.
☐ I know abbreviation rules.
☐ I recall Hawthorne’s quote.

Lecture 39: Report Style: Part II

Week 8 · Course book PDF pages 631–650 (printed pages 630–649)

Learning objectives

- Use active and passive voice appropriately in reports.
- Apply sentence-style techniques: subject-verb closeness, emphatic word order, parallel construction, splitting breathless sentences, avoiding noun clusters.
- Build unified, coherent, ordered paragraphs and use transitions.
- Compute the Gunning fog index and interpret it.
- Recall George Orwell's 'windowpane' principle.

Important definitions

ACTIVE VOICE

The subject performs the action; direct, clear, but can sound like an allegation.

PASSIVE VOICE

The subject receives the action (verb in third form); neutral, polite, impersonal, used to avoid blame.

EMPHATIC WORD ORDER

Arranging words so the important item is at the beginning or end of the sentence.

PARALLEL CONSTRUCTION

Using the same grammatical pattern for parts of a sentence.

BREATHLESS SENTENCE

A long sentence with no pause; split it into two or more.

NOUN CLUSTER (NOUN STRING)

A long chain of nouns (e.g. 'current group member meeting dates scheduling package format') that hides meaning; replace with verbs and prepositions.

TRANSITIONS (SIGNPOSTS)

Linking words and phrases that guide readers from one idea to the next.

READABILITY

The ease with which a text can be read and understood.

FOG INDEX

Robert Gunning's formula: 0.4 × (average sentence length + percentage of difficult words); a score below 12 means readable.

TOPIC SENTENCE

The main sentence of a paragraph to which others are related.

Core concepts

Variety as a style principle

- Repeating the same pattern ('I am thankful to…' repeatedly) is monotonous; vary voice, sentence length and order.
- Mix short and long sentences; give paragraphs for 'eye relief'.
- Examples of variety in acknowledgement: 'I am indebted to…', 'I acknowledge…'.

Active versus passive voice

- **Active**: direct and easier ("We do not advise the training division to concentrate its time, money and resources on a new programme").
- **Passive**: "Concentration… is not advisable from our point of view."
- Use passive to neutralise blame: "Since your workers did not pack the tape recorders, they got damaged" (allegation) → "Since the tape recorders were not packed properly…".
- Commands ('Shut the door') can be softened: "You are requested to close the door."
- "You are responsible" → "I think it is your responsibility."
- A complaint is written in active voice; the reply is often in passive.

Sentence style

- Put the **subject first and the verb just after it**; don't let the verb get lost at the end.
- Place important matter in the subject; use **emphatic word order**.
- Revise: "Some aspects of desktop publishing… have powerful control…" → "Today even a low-cost word processor can deliver…".
- Link clauses: "Parts are manufactured in Mexico, which has lower wage rates than the United States."
- Word order example: "He, as a management representative, is aware that he should uphold the authority to fire workers who disobey orders."
- Put the **positive first**: "We feel that by using this system we are missing some patients and therefore losing revenue."

Parallelism and splitting

- Parallel: “This book is good as a college text and even better as a means of enlarging their knowledge.”
- Split breathless sentences: “We are enclosing next month’s event calendar. If interested, kindly inform the concerned organiser.”
- Complex scientific sentences (adrenergic–cholinergic antagonism) become readable when split and using pronouns.

Noun clusters

Kick the noun habit, create the verb habit: “Please revise the schedule package format of group members’ meetings” instead of a string of nouns. Value-orientation example: bring the verb closer (“The concept of value orientation in this sense is thus…”).

Paragraph structure

- Three mantras: **unity, coherence, order**.
- Begin with a topic sentence; other sentences coordinate or subordinate to it using connecting words, repetition and pronouns.
- Develop paragraphs by comparison and contrast, cause and effect, classification, problem–solution.
- Avoid very long paragraphs; paragraph breaks give relief.

Transitions

- **Addition:** moreover, furthermore, besides, finally.
- **Cause / result:** hence, therefore, thus, consequently.
- **Contrast:** however, nonetheless, on the other hand, while.
- **Time:** earlier, now, later, after a while, meanwhile.
- **Repetition / summary:** in short, that is, thus.

Readability and fog index

- Gunning (1950s) fog index = 0.4 × (average sentence length + percentage of difficult words).
- Result **below 12** = readable.
- **Orwell:** style should be unobtrusive – like a windowpane through which information is clearly seen.

Types, classifications and characteristics

Transitions by function

Function	Examples
Addition	moreover, furthermore, besides, finally
Cause/effect	hence, therefore, thus, consequently
Contrast/comparison	however, nonetheless, on the other hand
Time	earlier, now, later, meanwhile
Repetition/summary	in short, that is

Paragraph development methods

Method	Use
Comparison and contrast	Show similarity/difference
Cause and effect	Explain reasons and results
Classification	Group items
Problem–solution	State problem then remedy

Theories, principles, models and contributors

FOG INDEX — ROBERT GUNNING (1950S)

Index = 0.4 × (average sentence length + % of difficult words); below 12 is readable.

UNOBTRUSIVE STYLE — GEORGE ORWELL

Style should be like a windowpane: invisible, letting information be clearly seen.

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

Tape recorders damaged because not packed (passive to avoid blame).

EXAMPLE

‘Please revise the schedule package format of group members’ meetings.’

EXAMPLE

Mexico wage-rate sentence.

EXAMPLE

Splitting the event-calendar sentence.

Comparison tables

Active versus passive voice in reports

Point	Active	Passive
Verb form	Verb follows subject	Be + past participle
Effect	Direct, forceful, may accuse	Neutral, polite, impersonal
Best use	Clarity, instructions, good news	Avoiding blame, bad news

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- Vary voice, sentence length and word order.
- Passive neutralises allegations.
- Subject then verb, close together.
- Positive points come first in comparisons.
- Split breathless sentences.
- Replace noun clusters with verbs.
- Paragraph = unity, coherence, order with topic sentence.
- Transitions are signposts.
- Fog index below 12 = readable.
- Gunning proposed the fog index; Orwell compared style to a windowpane.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W8 Q4	p.28	Report style: active voice	True/False
W8 Q12	p.30	Sentence style in reports	MSQ
W8 Q14	p.30	Transitions and coherence	MSQ

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

Good report style mixes active and passive voice (passive neutralises blame), keeps subject and verb close, uses emphatic word order, parallel construction and a mix of short and long sentences, and splits breathless sentences. Noun clusters should be replaced by verbs. Paragraphs need unity, coherence, order and a topic sentence, linked by transitions. Readability can be measured by Gunning's fog index (0.4 × (average sentence length + % difficult words)); a score below 12 is readable. Style should be unobtrusive, like a windowpane (Orwell).

Practice questions

Q1 (MCQ) A fog index below which value indicates readable writing?

A. 5

B. 12

C. 20

D. 30

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** Below 12.

Q2 (MCQ) Which voice is used to avoid accusing the reader?

A. Active

B. Passive

C. Imperative

D. Subjunctive

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** Passive neutralises allegation.

Q3 (MSQ) Which are transitions of contrast?

A. However

B. Nonetheless

C. Therefore

D. On the other hand

> **Answer:** A, B, D
> **Why:** 'Therefore' shows result.

Q4 (T/F) A long string of nouns makes a sentence clearer.

> **Answer:** False
> **Why:** Replace with verbs.

Q5 (Fill) A sentence that cannot be read in one breath is called a _____ sentence.

> **Answer:** breathless
> **Why:** Split it.

Q6 (Short) State the fog index formula.

> **Answer:** Fog index = 0.4 × (average sentence length + percentage of difficult words); below 12 is readable.
> **Why:** Proposed by Robert Gunning.

Revision checklist

☐ I know when to use active and passive.

☐ I can revise noun clusters.

☐ I can structure a paragraph.

☐ I can list transitions.

☐ I can calculate the fog index.

Lecture 40: Group Communication

Week 8 · Course book PDF pages 651–668 (printed pages 650–667)

Learning objectives

- Define a group and a team and differentiate them.
- List the tasks of groups and types of groups.
- State the advantages and disadvantages of group work, including groupthink and hidden agendas.
- Explain group dynamics: cooperation, loyalty, cohesiveness.
- Describe Tuckman’s stages of group development and the three group roles.

Important definitions

GROUP

A collection of people who work, interact and cooperate to achieve a common goal in a specified time; identity of members is taken individually and they share information and resources.

TEAM

A group of people with a common goal, within a limited time, having collective accountability; slogan: ‘one for all and all for one’.

FORMAL GROUP

A group formally constituted by an organisation.

INFORMAL GROUP

A group formed through personal relations; often works better in problem solving.

VIRTUAL GROUP

A group communicating online (WhatsApp, Facebook).

GROUPTHINK

A poor group decision resulting from majority pressure that ignores individual dissent.

HIDDEN AGENDA

A concealed personal aim of a member that harms group interaction.

GROUP DYNAMICS

Forces that keep a group working: cooperation, loyalty, cohesiveness.

COHESIVENESS

Staying together and committed to the goal despite disagreements.

CONSENSUS

General agreement reached by the group.

Core concepts

Why groups

- Humans form groups; modern tasks (events, reports, products, presentations) cannot be done alone or in short time.
- Example: a college cultural festival (‘Cognizance’) is a group effort; teams for music, lectures etc.
- This lecture itself is a team product (recording, editing, approving, posting).

Group versus team

- Group: common goal within a period; members taken individually.
- Team: a subdivision with its own specific goal and **collective accountability**; shared leadership; joint accountability for performance.
- Both share a common goal, cooperation, identification of skills, leadership and accountability.

Tasks of groups and teams

1. Solve problems.
2. Investigate an opportunity (new product, policy).
3. Write reports.
4. Give oral or group presentations (experts present their parts).
5. Devise, evolve and produce new products (e.g. incubation centres).

Types of groups

- **Formal**, **informal** (often more effective) and **virtual** groups.
- Informal groups help problem solving: members help each other beyond formal roles.

Advantages of groups

- More information and resources.
- Diversity of views and experience.
- Better acceptance of decisions and consensus after weighing pros and cons.
- Better performance.
- Sense of belonging; broadened knowledge.

Disadvantages of groups

- Rigid ideas and ego clashes cause wasted, frustrating time.
- ‘Know-it-all’ delusion; unacceptance of consensus.
- Groups within groups; individual opinions ignored.
- **Groupthink** and poor decisions.

- **Hidden agendas**.
- Difficulty coordinating diverse backgrounds; a ‘messiah’/leader is needed.

Group dynamics

- **Cooperation** – communication clears roadblocks.
- **Loyalty** – willingness to make small sacrifices.
- **Cohesiveness** – staying together despite differences (utensils make noise).

Tuckman’s stages

1. **Forming** – introductions, rapport building; members are new.
2. **Storming** – clash of ideas; beneficial for new ideas.
3. **Norming** – peace; members mellow, accept views, filter.
4. **Performing** – energetic, effective work.
5. **Adjourning** – group dissolves after the task (added later by Tuckman).

Bruce Tuckman, psychologist; initially four stages, adjourning added later.

Group roles

- **Self-oriented roles** – members pursuing self-interest, wanting control or withdrawing.
- **Maintenance roles** – encouraging, harmonising, compromising to keep the group together.
- **Task-facilitating roles** – initiating, giving and seeking information, setting procedures.

Leader and Drucker

A leader coordinates and secures consensus. **Peter Drucker:** “When the ship goes down, you do not call a meeting. The captain gives an order or everybody drowns.” (crisis needs decisive leadership). Members must also consider ethics and personal responsibility. Next lecture: leadership.

Types, classifications and characteristics

Tuckman’s stages of group development

Stage	Characteristic
Forming	Introductions, uncertainty, building rapport
Storming	Conflict of ideas; clashes
Norming	Acceptance, norms, harmony
Performing	Productive teamwork
Adjourning	Task completed; group disbands

Group roles

Role type	Behaviour
Self-oriented	Self-interest, control, withdrawal
Maintenance	Encourage, harmonise, compromise
Task-facilitating	Initiate, give/seek information, set procedure

Theories, principles, models and contributors

STAGES OF GROUP DEVELOPMENT — BRUCE TUCKMAN

Forming, storming, norming, performing and (later) adjourning.

CRISIS LEADERSHIP — PETER DRUCKER

When the ship goes down, you do not call a meeting; the captain gives an order.

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

College cultural festival (Cognizance) with music and lecture teams.

EXAMPLE

Incubation centre developing a new product.

EXAMPLE

Task force that is adjourned after completing its work.

EXAMPLE

WhatsApp virtual groups.

Comparison tables

Group versus team

Point	Group	Team
Goal	Common goal	Specific goal within group goal
Accountability	Individual identity	Collective accountability
Motto	Work together	One for all, all for one

Advantages versus disadvantages of groups

Advantages	Disadvantages
More information	Ego clashes, wasted time
Diverse views	Individual views ignored
Better performance	Groupthink, hidden agendas
Sense of belonging	Coordination difficulty

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- Tuckman stages: forming, storming, norming, performing, adjourning.
- Team = collective accountability.
- Tasks: solve problems, investigate opportunities, write reports, present, develop products.
- Types of groups: formal, informal, virtual.
- Group dynamics: cooperation, loyalty, cohesiveness.
- Roles: self-oriented, maintenance, task-facilitating.
- Groupthink leads to poor decisions.
- Drucker: the captain gives an order.
- Informal groups can work better than formal ones.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W0 Q1	p.1	Soft skills in teamwork	MCQ
W8 Q3	p.28	When not to hold meetings	True/False
W8 Q7	p.29	Team membership	MCQ
W8 Q10	p.29	Group roles: maintenance	MCQ
W8 Q11	p.29	Group roles: task facilitating	MSQ
W8 Q15	p.30	Group communication	MSQ

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

A group is a collection of people cooperating for a common goal in a set time; a team is a subdivision with collective accountability. Groups solve problems, investigate opportunities, write reports, give presentations and develop products. They may be formal, informal or virtual. Advantages are more information, diversity, acceptance, performance and belonging; disadvantages include ego clashes, ignoring individuals, groupthink and hidden agendas. Group dynamics: cooperation, loyalty, cohesiveness. Tuckman's stages: forming, storming, norming, performing, adjourning. Roles are self-oriented, maintenance and task-facilitating.

Practice questions

Q1 (MCQ) Which stage of Tuckman's model involves conflict of ideas?

A. Forming

B. Storming

C. Norming

D. Adjourning

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** Storming: clashes of ideas.

Q2 (MCQ) Collective accountability characterises a:

A. Crowd

B. Team

C. Audience

D. Mob

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** Team: one for all.

Q3 (MSQ) Group dynamics include:

A. Cooperation

B. Loyalty

C. Cohesiveness

D. Hidden agenda

> **Answer:** A, B, C
> **Why:** Hidden agenda is a drawback.

Q4 (T/F) The fifth stage, adjourning, was added later by Tuckman.

> **Answer:** True
> **Why:** Initially four stages.

Q5 (Fill) Poor decisions caused by majority pressure are called _____.

> **Answer:** groupthink
> **Why:** Individual views are ignored.

Q6 (Short) List two disadvantages of group work.

> **Answer:** Ego clashes and wasted time; groupthink or individual views being ignored (also hidden agendas).
> **Why:** Groups need a leader.

Revision checklist

☐ I can define group and team.
☐ I know group tasks and types.
☐ I can list advantages and disadvantages.
☐ I know the five Tuckman stages.
☐ I know the three roles.